Linguistics/Psychology 406
Psycholinguistics
Fall 2026

Course ID and Title: PSYC/LING 406
Psycholinguistics
Prerequisites: PSYC 100 or LING 210
Semester and day/time: 20263 TuTh 11:00-12:20
Classroom: GFS 228

Course Instructor/ Director: **Jason Zevin**; SGM724/Zoom, zevin@usc.edu.
Hours: By appointment

Course description
Psycholinguistics is an interdisciplinary field that focuses on how people learn, produce and understand language. The specific goal of this course is to expose students to the central topics, methods and major findings of psycholinguistics. We will discuss what is known about language comprehension and production, and you will also learn about the experiments and procedures that researchers use to investigate the psychological processes that underlie them. Students will have the opportunity to get some hands-on experience with data analysis and mini-experiments.

Course requirements

1. Readings. You are expected to read all assigned chapters and papers *before* the class in which they will discussed, so that you can fully comprehend and participate in class discussion. Classes are designed with the expectation that students have done the reading beforehand.

2. **Participation and in-class exercises**. You are expected to participate in class discussion by actively asking questions and being prepared to discuss the course material. We will occasionally do brief in-class exercises and they will be graded on a *credit / no credit* basis, and count towards the attendance and participation part of your final grade. The activities aim to build on and extend the topics covered in class. They also let the instructor keep an eye on students' understanding of the concepts and ideas covered in the course, to see if there are topics that need further explanation or clarification.

3. **Writing assignments.** There will also be some writing assignments to be completed outside of class time. These assignments will involve a range of tasks, such as answering questions about the readings, interpreting data, or researching a topic on the web or in the library. Your answers will be graded based on how thoroughly and carefully the assignment was completed and what level of understanding and mastery of the concept the answers reveal.

4. **Exams**. There will be two exams mid-term given in class on the dates noted below, worth 20% of your grade, each. There will also be a cumulative final, focused (50% or more) on the material in the final third of the course.

Grading scheme:
Midterm exams 60%
Final exam 25%
Homework and short assignments 15%

Class schedule

Aug 25 Introduction / Basic Linguistics 1 - Phonetics and phonology (*Menn, Chapter 1A)*

Aug 27 Basic Linguistics 2 - Morphology and syntax (*Menn, Chapter 1B)*

Sept 1 Basic concepts from psychology and neuroscience *(Menn, Chapter 2*)

Sept 3 Language research and cognitive neuroscience (*Finger; Posner et al.)*

Sept 8 Linguistics and the Cognitive Revolution (*Chomsky's review of Verbal Behavior); *short paper topic introduced: "How do large language models (LLMs) change the way we think about psycholinguistics?"

Sept 10 Speech Errors, and a model of speech production I *(Menn, Chapter 3)*

Sept 15 Speech Errors, and a model of speech production II (*Menn, Chapter 4)*

Sept 17 Experimental Methods (*Menn, Chapter 5)*

Sept 22 – Exam 1 review

Sept 24 Exam 1

Sept 29 Experimental Studies of Speech Perception *Diehl et al (Intro and pp. 155-159)*

Oct 1 Experimental Studies at the Lexical-Phonetic Interface. (*Ganong; McClelland et al.)*

Oct 6 Experimental Studies of Sentence Processing *(Altmann)*

Oct 13 Aphasias (*Menn, Chapter 6*)

Oct 14 Language Development (*Menn, Chapter 7)*

Oct 20 More Language Development!

Oct 22 Critical Periods for L1 *Mayberry*

Oct 27 Second Language Acquisition (*Menn, Chapter 9) --- Short paper on LLMs due!*

Oct 39 – Sensitive Periods for L2 *DeKeyser*

Nov 3 Exam 2

Nov 5 Reading (*Menn, Chapter 8)*

Nov 10 Computational models of word recognition *(Seidenberg)*

Nov 12 More modeling: Language Impairment and models of the Past Tense *(Joanisse)*

Nov 17 Language and Thought (*Boroditsky)*

Nov 19 Language in other modalities: Sign and Braille (*Bavelier et al.)*

Nov 24 Task analysis and practical issues *(Menn, Chapter 10/Afterword)*

(Thanksgiving)

Dec 1 Final review/catch-up and/or something fun

Dec 3 In-class final exam (in lieu of scheduled final exam on 12/15)

Accessibility
The course has been organized to be accessible to students who are unable to attend in person for any reason. Lectures will be presented in person at the scheduled time (unless otherwise noted),streamed synchronously on Zoom, and recorded for later viewing.

Students requesting academic accommodations based on a disability are required to register with Office of Student Accessibility Services each semester. A letter of verification for approved accommodations can be obtained from OSAS when adequate documentation is filed. If you do not have an OSAS letter and need any kind of accommodation, you can always ask me and I'll see what I can do. Please use this form to make requests: https://forms.gle/Hn9LLASqCt9rxhDh9

Statement on Academic Integrity
USC seeks to maintain an optimal learning environment. General principles of academic honesty include the concept of respect for the intellectual property of others, the expectation that individual work will be submitted unless otherwise allowed by an

instructor, and the obligations both to protect one's own academic work from misuse by others as well as to avoid using another's work as one's own. All students are expected to understand and abide by these principles. Scampus, the Student Guidebook, contains the Student Conduct Code in Section 11.00, while the recommended sanctions are located in Appendix A: http://www.usc.edu/dept/publications/SCAMPUS/gov/. Students will be referred to the Office of Student Judicial Affairs and Community Standards for further review, should there be any suspicion of academic dishonesty. The Review process can be found at: http://www.usc.edu/student-affairs/SJACS/.

We will talk about large language models, and especially their theoretical predecessors, quite a bit in this course. Please do not use one to generate any text for the assignments (with the obvious exception of illustrative examples clearly labeled as such). Writing is thinking. If you are not writing your own assignments, you are not thinking about the material, and not meeting the goal of the assignment, which after all, is not just to generate some relevant text, but to think about the course material.

Emergency Preparedness/Course Continuity:
In case of emergency, and travel to campus is difficult, USC executive leadership will announce an electronic way for instructors to teach students in their residence halls or homes using a combination of Blackboard, teleconferencing, and other technologies.

Required Texts

Menn, L. and Dronkers, N (2016) *Psycholinguistics: Introduction and Applications: Second Edition.* Plural Publishing. Available from the publisher or as an eBook here: https://www.pluralpublishing.com/publications/psycholinguistics-introduction-and-applications (also available to rent for half price at various sites)

Various chapters and articles linked above, provided as pdfs.